



Blue Mosque

An imposing Ottoman place of worship especially famed for its lavish blue-tiled interior

Dominating the skyline of the old quarter of Istanbul, Turkey, the Sultan Ahmet Mosque, also known as the Blue Mosque, was the late flowering of an empire in decline. When the 19-year-old Ottoman sultan for whom the mosque is named ordered its construction in 1609, his empire was reeling from defeats in the wars against Austria and Iran. Creating a vast Muslim building to rival the nearby Christian-built Hagia Sophia was an act of defiance, ignoring the shrunken state of the Ottoman empire's finances.

Blue-tiled interior

Sultan Ahmet's architect, Sedefkar Mehmed Aga (c.1540–1617), designed the mosque complex, incorporating a religious school (*madrasa*) and a charitable hospice, as well as a prayer hall and courtyard. Built on a grand scale, it is topped by a central dome surrounded by four half-domes and six slender minarets. The austere gray-stone exterior contrasts with the brilliantly decorative interior of the prayer hall, lit by 200 stained-glass windows—a gift from the Ottomans'

Christian ally, Venice—and lined with 20,000 blue tiles from the imperial ceramic production center at İznik. The mosque was completed shortly before Sultan Ahmet's death, at the age of 27, in 1617.



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△ OTTOMAN SPLENDOR

The Blue Mosque was the last major mosque of the Classical period of Ottoman architecture. Here, its six minarets thrust into the sky of Old Istanbul.

▽ TILED INTERIOR

The brightly colored İznik tiles lining the mosque are shown to advantage by light from the many windows in the domed ceiling.